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Alex Gonzalez

the havens

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havens

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Chapter 35

I took a long drive.

I ended up at Branford Library - Blackstone to be precise - lest I think that's what it was called. I was caught up worrying about money again - the 5k I ended up making from spoils of the treasure hunt last summer - rested pretty - in a 4.5% APR money market account that was tempting me terribly.

I, having no foreseeable income other than the Alderman stipend of \$3,600 promised to me come May - was fighting desperation.

The last website I built was for an author, which whom - I will not name, no no no, but it was okay - the gentleman paid me 3 installments of \$4000 dollars - which after taxes - came out to be three installments of \$950 dollars - which honestly - sucked - being that my rent was also \$950. I didn't want to be in the red - but if something didn't change soon - my little budgeting app would be very, very sad and send me all types of notifications that I was overdrawn and out of whack. Fine.

I calculated my fixed costs and determined that the money for food and what not would have to come elsewhere - thus, I took 2k from my life savings of 9k - and divided things so I had 2k in a checking account - and 7k in another

money market account - getting 4.5% a year. The 5k from the treasure was separate - untouchable - sacred. I would rather wither on the streets than to use it for something temporary like rent or a grumbling belly - no no no, that treasure had to be used for a good purpose.

There were times where I dreamt of going back for more gold - for I knew where more lay, but after the sequence of events that took place last summer - I thought I would hold off. Wait - at least 3 months.

I used the GPT to calculate my deficit and found that number to be 1000 - that of which - would be deducted from my emergency fund which now has \$800.... Okay - that's enough... enough of this all.

I shut my laptop and began to shadow box in a bit in the library bathroom, being that it was a single stall affair. I stopped at P&M in Branford - before taking a long sunset drive through 142.

...

In the quiet nights and wanders around the havens - I noticed newspaper stands - vending machines - and red boxes. I saw amazon pick up trays and Fedex drop off trays - and I thought about the busy lives of students.

I, having a solid connection with my mother back home - am keen on dropping off my laundry - once a month - when I pay my visit and at first, I felt bad about it - but it is something we do together.

Laundry.

Laundry Laundry
Laundry - Coffee Coffee
Coffee.

Josh knocked on the door during my this verbose ping pong marathon of swirling task driven thoughts. Do this, do that, what about this, what if that, my brain began to hiss at the notion of being interrupted.

And then Josh knocked again - and I knew, that I couldn't pretend to have my headphones in any longer.

"Hey man - sorry I had my head phones on"

"oh No worries - no worries..."

"What's up"

"yeah.... Our bikes got stolen"

Chapter 36

Fuck New Haven.

I couldn't take it - and neither could Kenny Lewis - we both were steaming down in the kitchen - Lewis over justice - me over just the feeling of obstruction - and sick and tired all of the gangster nonsense - I wanted the gangster to change their ways - and just be cool and relax - and stop stealing - and just change their vibes - I didn't like the idea of punishment - but I did want folks to feel sorry for what they have done.

Kenny Lewis believed strongly in the justice system and wanted them to face a jury and go through the process - and I was like dude - those bikes were like 400 total - probably more - probably less - who cares.

He didn't like that - for he cared - for reasons, still I can't make out.

Regardless he made it clear that he'd be investing in ring cameras - Josh said he'd put 20 towards that - and I agreed to as well, but I knew that Kenny Lewis knew that I knew the price would be closer to 500.

"Dear Bike Thief,

Attached to this letter are some sunflower seeds - go right now - we hope that you plant them in a garden of your choosing - and have fun with it baby - stop being so wack - plant a plant and stop being so gangster - you aren't impressing me - but you could - What WOULD impress me - is if you go and plant a plant - a sunflower - and walk by it everyday - and write a poem - and stop the bullshit - we get it - life sucks - but common - we dare you to plant that plant and challenge you to be cute about it.

If you want to steal again - our passcode is 0283 - that will open up a key which will reveal a key if you want to take our stuff - go for it - we're going to be away in two weeks on holiday - so - that would be a good time - if not all good - just please keep this hush - What's your name?"

Kenny Lewis shrugged his shoulders - "I guess you could write that."

Josh was more reassuring than us all - and we took a nice pause that night and watched the Office on Peacock. In the end - I didn't trash the letter - but hung it on our fridge. Kenny Lewis was looking out the window, scouring the streets.

I gave him a hug and he flinched a bit - then froze - then let it happen. I haven't hugged a man like that for a while - and to be honest - I loved it - it felt good to hug that frozen man.

Chapter 37

That night I went to bed and juiced up on google maps - hoping to scout the havens and make a bit of a fuss - but I was tired so I decided to go to the coffee pedaler in the morning.

The Coffee Peddler - would be a good place to start - mainly because it was so close to home and I was feeling lazy.

My initial plan was to start with a series of small wins and progressively increase the small wins into small milestones that I would have on some small chart that I'd hang with a magnet on a mini fridge.

My morning, at hand, was simple - go into every coffee shop and examine, take notes and steal.

I would trek into every single fucking coffee shop in New Haven - and steal - steal ideas - and emulate.

The plan was to plan a trip to each shop - and take notes of all of the things - all things. Unique things - things I dislike - things like a POS system - a refrigerator - the ceiling fan - the pretty dangling - Edison bulbs - things like that. Things like that I'd write in writing - and later in excel - and then - when I collect enough data - I'd cross compare and have chat gpt to find me free alternatives to acquire each and every device needed to operate a functional coffee shop. Facebook marketplace began to take stock in my mind - but aye - I wasn't keen on meeting up with folks. But whatever that might bring - I'd bring Dominic - maybe we'd find Kenny Lewis' bike.

INITIALLY -

I figured IT BE BEST to put most of the chips into an espresso machine - and only have that going - that and constant milk. I figured I could Pinterest some machines later - and just rest easy in the fact that eBay exists, that Alibaba exists, that with the right sms notifications - I could find a sale or better yet - get some angel investor out there - somewhere - to send me an espresso machine.

I became overwhelmed at the thought of investment capital - so I went on ebay just to see what I was up against and got pumped up when I saw that they had a brand new espresso machine - *"20 bar coffee machine s/s outdoors coffee"* - whatever that meant.

s/s outdoors
coffee
laundry
outside
outside

prototype

Prototype - Prototype.

I liked the idea of a prototype.

Prototype a laundry machine cafe -

For the idea could be viral only if we had a prototype in the backyard. Get a bunch of old laundry machines together - i could have Dominic and the boys pick it up - and then put flyers around town for a potluck cafe laundromat prototype and investor pancake brunch - all in the backyard. Yes. The backyard laundromat cafe.

If we made enough flyers around town - and designed them pretty enough on Canva - we could advertise a backyard prototype for the popup laundromat cafe.

We needed Milk.

I wondered if there was a market for milk men that still came through, like they would have in the old days - and if not - why not? I thought about what it would take to make such a thing happen - would folks be interested? I am not sure - for I wasn't alive during the milk days - but the thought of someone kindly greeting me each morning with some warm milk - in a little car - that is cute - charmed me a bit.

Maybe the bike stealing gangster just needed some milk.

About the Author



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